

RIGHT MOVE: Muslims now want to be a part of the political process

report by August 20 will lead to a protest rally. "Sensing trouble," he says, "filmmaker Mahesh Bhatt called Sarfaraz Arzoo, one of the Muslim leaders and asked him to talk to the chief minister. Of the 250 protestors, only seven were taken to the chief minister, who asked them to call off the rally and promised to announce setting up of special courts. They wanted to dilute the issue and destroy the movement." On October 24, the Government announced the setting up of four special courts, which will try only 18 cases. The Congress's policy of managing the Muslims is now no longer a secret and nor is this disillusionment confined to Mumbai. Different parts of the state are now witnessing a silent uprising against the Government.

The recent Malegaon Municipal Corporation elections is a clear signal. Gruesome bomb blasts at a mosque and shoddy relief work that followed made sure the party was routed in the polls and the four-month-old Indian Muslim Congress Party (IMCP) emerged the largest gainer. The election issues weren't communal but the focus was on development and employment. "The city lacks proper roads, basic civic amenities and electricity. The Congress and Janata Dal corporators have done nothing," explains Mufti Mohammed Ismail, head of IMCP who had almost struck a deal with the Shiv Sena to keep the Congress out.

However, IMCP claims the Sena let them down. One of its members informed the Congress that IMCP was in talks with five independents. The Sena kept them waiting for a week by saying they were awaiting instructions from their seniors. In the meantime, Congress MLA Sheikh Rashid convinced the independents to support them. They finally had to reach a compromise with the Congress, thanks to the TINA (there-is-no-alternative) factor.

If there are Muslim activists who have floated their own outfits to outdo the Congress, others like Pasha Patel



prefer to sleep with the enemy. Even though his party has taken a stand against the Sachar Committee, Patel is running a "Support Sachar" campaign in the state. In December, over one lakh Muslims will participate in the Insaaf Do rally in Nagpur to demand the report's implementation. "The report is an X-ray of the Muslims over

the past 60 years," says Patel, now a BJP MLC. The farmer activist has been able to collect six lakh signatures in blood in support of this campaign and now hopes to draw attention to issues of education and development. "Today, 34 per cent Muslims are lying in jails and only 2 per cent are in government jobs. The Congress has killed both the farmer and the Muslim," he claims. Disgruntled with the secular parties, he had joined BJP in 2002 against the wishes of his supporters, who felt he would betray the cause of Muslims.

The Muslim leadership is fast realising the need to be a part of the political process to effect a change and the possibility of a third front is being actively discussed. "The Congress tries to buy out Muslim leaders by offering them material benefits or symbolic positions like heads of commissions," says Shaikh. Patel explains that Muslims are not given a chance to participate in political activities. "Muslim-dominated wards are either reserved for SC/STs or are merged with general wards," he says. To correct this, Muslim social welfare groups are planning to join hands with the Samajwadi Party, BSP and Dalit organisations to build a strong third front. "The Muslim leadership is coming together to build confidence against the Congress. The Nyay Andolan is only the beginning," states Shaikh. Whether Maharashtra will see a repeat of Uttar Pradesh is something only time will tell, but the seeds of Muslim unrest have definitely been sown in the state.

WHY ARE THEY UNHAPPY?

■ The state Government continues to drag its feet over Srikrishna Commission Report, despite promising its implementation during 1999 and 2004 state polls.

■ A compensation of only Rs 1 lakh was given to Malegaon blast victims, who were largely Muslims while the victims of Mumbai train blasts and Hyderabad blast got Rs 6 lakh.

■ Teachers in Malegaon's municipal schools have not been paid salaries for seven months.

■ Wakf properties and funds are not properly managed.

■ Only a symbolic representation in state government.

■ Muslim-dominated constituencies have been reserved for backward castes.



"The Congress thrives on the policy of not letting a good Muslim leadership emerge."

RAIS SHAIKH, COORDINATOR OF NYAY ANDOLAN